

NO BOUNDARIES

Next-gen consoles, multi-core processing, and all that jazz...The world of gaming is changing, and hardware vendors are going over the top trying to keep up



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Playing games on the move was limited to *Snake* on the cell phone or to Nintendo games on a GameBoy platform. Until recently. On the console front, both the Nintendo DS and the Sony PlayStation Portable have opened up new markets and new avenues to gameplay—while the DS offers a completely new interface (driven by both touch and sound), the PSP brings console-level graphics and gameplay to a handheld device, not to mention its multimedia capabilities.

Beyond these two recent additions, players haven't had much success establishing new platforms in the mobile space. Gizmondo came and went with barely a whimper, N-Gage was met with a lukewarm reception, and niche players such as GP2X are, well, niche.

The market might see some new platforms in the future. Microsoft may or may not release a handheld version of its Xbox console, but it has certainly take a step into the mobile gaming space through its cell phone, PDA, and now Origami software. Origami is

Mobile Gaming Omnipresent

the concept of a handheld PC or as Microsoft calls it, ultra-mobile PC (UMPC). It is simply taking the Windows OS and running it in a handheld form factor. Hardware willing, any game capable of running on the PC should also be able to run on a UMPC, which should open up the possibility of playing old DOS and Windows games on the move. An interesting hardware development here would be the scaling down of the current generation of gaming GPUs—ATI, for example, has recently talked about stripping down its R500 GPU to make it suitable to a handheld form-factor. There are also rumours that NVIDIA has a chip in the works for the next version of the PSP.

Microsoft has another hardware device up its sleeve in the form of the Zune. It has always been conjectured both by outsiders and by Microsoft itself that the Zune can do more than just play music. It already syncs with an Xbox Live profile; could it not also run Xbox Live Arcade games in the future? If not in its current avatar, certainly in a newer version.

Nokia is perhaps the biggest competitor to Microsoft in this space. It already tried to establish itself as a phone-plus-gaming console with the N-Gage—while that initiative might have failed, Nokia probably won't stop trying, especially when there's a large, untapped market to be, umm, tapped. One of the ways ahead for Nokia would

be to create tools for creating and maintaining a gaming platform on Nokia devices, instead of a dedicated device such as the N-Gage. In early 2006, it took the first step to such a platform by releasing an SDK (software development kit) containing tools and a consumer interface to access and purchase games using a cell phone.

Let's not forget Apple. One can already pick up casual games from the likes of PopCap at the iTunes store, plus rumours point to at least two new products that will have gaming capabilities—one being the Apple TV set-top box which will sit in the living room, and the other, the current talk-of-the-town—the iPhone. The iPhone is a closed platform—much like a gaming console—and you won't find games and software being developed for the device by just any software house. This does not exclude big names though: recent rumours point to both PopCap and EA developing games for the device. While the iPhone's specs haven't been made public, it's not too much of a stretch to imagine the hardware capable of running some decent games: it can play videos, it runs a stripped-down version of OS X, and has multiple ARM processors.

Gaming on the move is an exciting prospect; imagine playing a game of *Halo* while paying superficial attention to a boring meeting—which you must never do. No sir.

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